

The c5 London

A practical black repertoire guide from Daniel Naroditsky's London System speed-run lesson

This guide is deliberately written like a small opening chapter rather than a sheet of variations. The goal is to make the positions feel familiar: why Black chooses the early ...c5, why the queen goes to b6, when the queen should leave b6, and how the game can shift from queenside pressure into a kingside attack.

All boards are shown from Black's seat, matching a black-repertoire study view. The diagrams use the app's chesscom-neo piece set, not letter markers.

The repertoire in one breath

- Meet 1.d4 and 2.Bf4 with ...Nf6 and ...c5. Black wants early central contact, not a slow symmetry contest.
- After 3.e3, exchange on d4 before playing ...Qb6. This makes b2 and d4 the two questions White has to answer.
- If White plays Nc3, do not be greedy with ...Qxb2. Play ...a6 first, then ...d5, because b5 is the square that matters.
- After Nf3, ...Bg4 is the move to remember. The pin is really pressure on d4.
- When White becomes passive, improve: ...e6, ...Bd6, ...Qc7, ...O-O, ...b5, and c-file pressure.
- If White damages the kingside with gxf3 ideas, Black can become the attacker with ...g6, ...Nh5, and ...Qd8-h4.

Chapter 1: Why ...c5 Changes the Conversation

The London player usually wants a familiar triangle: d4, e3, c3, Nf3, Bd3, and a quiet middlegame. Naroditsky's recommendation starts by refusing that comfort. The move ...c5 hits d4 before White has completed the shell. If White ignores the tension, Black can often decide when to exchange; if White clarifies it, Black gets a structure with targets and imbalances.



1. The immediate challenge

1.d4 Nf6 2.Bf4 c5

Black refuses the slow London story at once. The move ...c5 is not a bluff; it asks White to define the center before their usual c3/e3/Nf3/Bd3 shell is complete.



2. Exchange first, then ask questions

3.e3 cxd4 4.exd4 Qb6

Black first creates the pawn-structure imbalance, then puts the queen on b6. The two targets are b2 and d4, and White has to defend without making concessions.



3. The greedy pawn warning

5. Nc3 Qxb2?! 6. Nb5

This is the line Naroditsky warns against. Once the knight jumps to b5, Black is dragged into concrete theory and White gets dangerous initiative.



4. The practical solution: ...a6

5. Nc3 a6

The quiet-looking ...a6 is the repertoire move. It covers b5 first, so ...d5 can come without letting White freeze a black knight on a6.

Chapter 2: The Main-Line Pressure Build

Once ...a6 has covered b5, Black is ready for ...d5. This is where the opening becomes more strategic. The queen on b6 created discomfort, but Black should not worship that square. Pieces have jobs. When the b6 queen has done its job, it can move to c7 and serve a new plan.



5. Rb1 costs White a tempo

6 . Rb1

White protects b2 without playing b3, but the rook move is not free. Black has provoked a defensive move and can now play in the center.



6. Now the center is ready for ...d5

6 . . . d5

Because ...a6 has already covered b5, Black can play ...d5 consistently. The opening has become an Exchange Caro-Kann type structure with extra London-specific pressure.



7. The pin is about d4

7 . Nf3 Bg4

The pin is not cosmetic. The knight on f3 is the main defender of d4, and because the knight on c3 blocks the c-pawn, White cannot easily support the center with c3.



8. White must consider Ne5

8 . Be2 Nc6 9 . Ne5

This is White's active equalizing try. Passive protection lets Black improve; Ne5 asks Black to resolve the pin before the pressure becomes permanent.



9. If White trades correctly

9... Bxe2 10. Nxe2 e6 11. c3

White recaptures with the knight so c3 becomes available. Black is still perfectly comfortable, but this is a more resilient version for White.



10. Passive overprotection

9 . Be3 e6

Be3 is a psychological concession: White moves backward to hold d4. Black should simply develop and enjoy the fact that White is running out of useful plans.



11. Develop like an Exchange Caro

10. 0-0 Bd6

In this structure, the dark-squared bishop belongs on d6. Black reinforces the center and prepares a normal, healthy middlegame rather than chasing tactics too early.



12. Keep the bishop pair for now

11. h3 Bh5

Do not take on f3 automatically. Naroditsky keeps the bishop pair until the capture creates a concrete structural gain.



13. The queen changes jobs

12. a3 Qc7

A major lesson: a piece can finish its first job. The queen no longer needs b6; on c7 it eyes c-file play, supports e5, discourages b4, and clears b7-b5.

Chapter 3: The Squeeze Becomes a Middlegame

The move ...b5 is not a cheap threat. It is a space move. Black clamps c4, restricts White's pieces, and asks White to find a plan. The important practical lesson is that a player under pressure often lashes out. When White plays b4, the game changes: c4 becomes a permanent square, and Black can begin organizing around it.



14. Space first: ...b5

13. Qd2 0-0 14. Kh1 b5

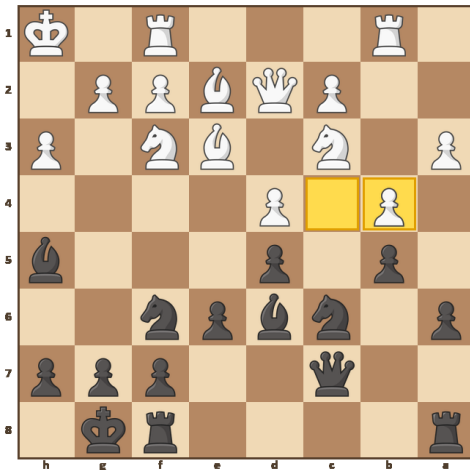
The point of ...b5 is space and control. Black clamps c4 and makes White feel short of plans; ...b4 is not automatically the idea.



15. White should remember a4

15. a4

This is one of the most important defensive ideas in the video. If Black expands with ...b5, White can chip the structure with a4 and make the game tactical.



16. The panic push b4

15. b4?!

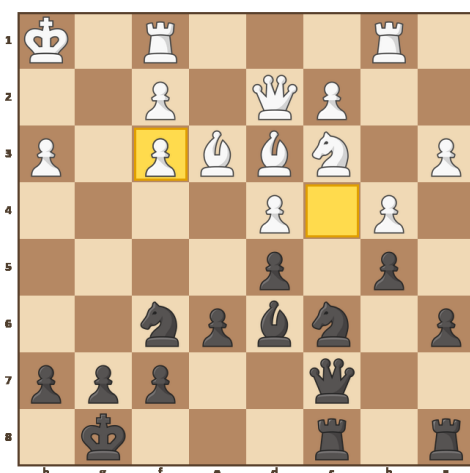
This looks active but gives Black c4. The move changes the whole board: Black now has a weak square to occupy and a c-file target to pressure.



17. Assemble on the c-file

15... Rfc8

The rook comes to the side where the game is being played. Black is not attacking the king yet; first the queenside needs to be squeezed.



18. Give up the bishop only for structure

16. Bd3 Bxf3 17. gxf3

Now the capture is justified. White's kingside pawns are damaged and Black can begin to think about both c4 and king safety.



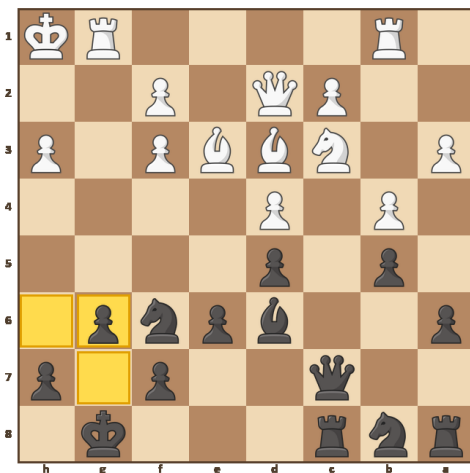
19. The retreating knight route

17...Nb8

This is the kind of move that makes the game educational. The knight retreats so it can travel to d7, b6, and c4. In closed positions, the route matters more than the tempo count.

Chapter 4: Switching Fronts

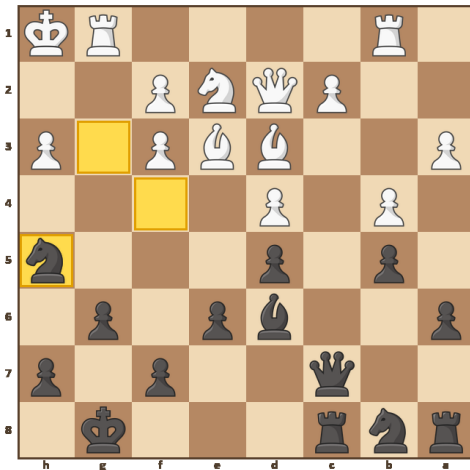
One of the strongest lessons in the video is that Black should not keep playing on the same side forever. After White's kingside structure is damaged, moves that look ugly in the abstract can become very practical. ...g6 is a defensive move, ...Nh5 is a restraining move, and ...Qd8-h4 is the bridge from positional pressure to tactics.



20. The ugly-looking but safe ...g6

18.Rg1 g6

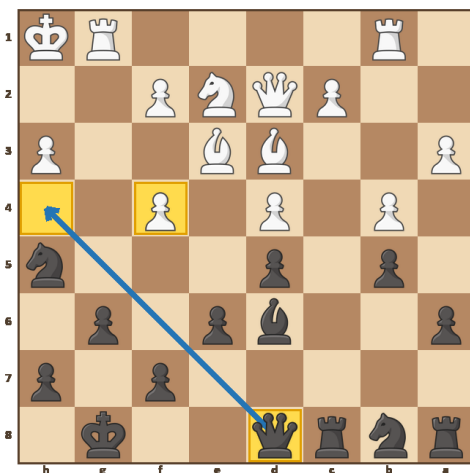
The pawn looks ugly, but it solves real problems. On g6 it blunts Bh6/Qh6 ideas and takes away cheap kingside targets.



21. The rim knight with a job

19. Ne2 Nh5

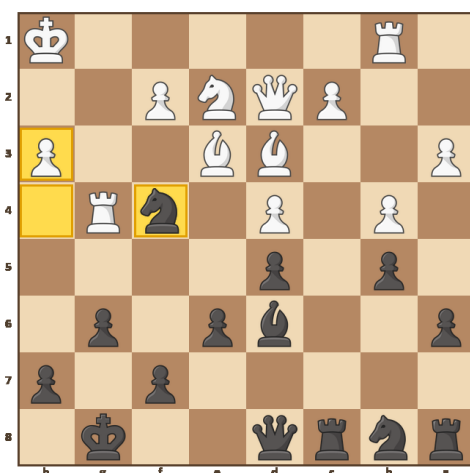
The knight on h5 is not misplaced. It controls g3 and f4, restrains White, and opens the queen route from d8 to h4.



22. The queen finds h4

20. f4 Qd8

Once the knight moves from f6, the queen can use the d8-h4 path. Black has converted queenside pressure into kingside attacking chances.



23. The pretty tactic appears

21. Rg4 Nxf4

This is the tactical conversion moment. Naroditsky notes that the beautiful move must still be checked against White's defensive resources.

22.Bxf4 Qh4

Chapter 5: White's Resources and Side Roads

A good repertoire chapter should not only show Black's dream. White has resources. The move a4 is the queenside lever to remember after ...b5. Early c3, dxc5, d5, b3, and a3 each lead to a different kind of game, but the same principles carry over: pressure d4, watch b5, avoid greedy pawn grabs when White has initiative, and develop into healthy structures.



25. Side line: 3.c3 Qb6

3 . c3 Qb6

The appeal of ...c5 is that c3 does not solve everything. The queen still asks about b2 and d4, and Black can often get a comfortable queenside file after exchanges.



26. Side line: 3.dxc5 Na6

3 . dxc5 Na6

Black should not fear the capture. The knight attacks c5 and lets Black recover the pawn with active development.



27. Regaining c5 with the queen

4. Qd4 Qa5+ 5. c3 Qxc5

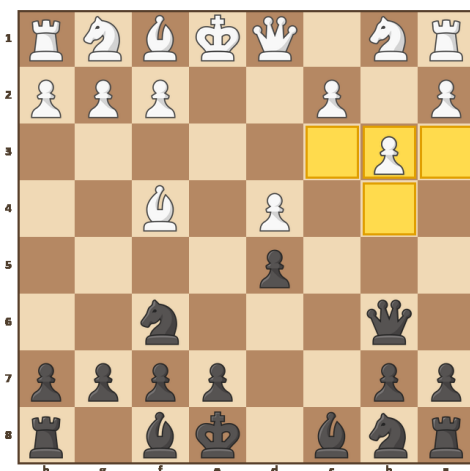
A practical detail: if ...Nxc5 would allow b4, use the queen recapture. Black keeps the pawn structure healthy and the queens active.



28. Side line: 3.d5 and ...e5

3. d5 d6 4. Nc3 e5

Against d5, Black aims for a reversed King's Indian/Benoni flavor. The d6 pawn may look backward, but Black expects to prepare ...d5 later.



29. If White plays b3

5. b3 d5

b3 defends b2 but weakens the dark squares. Black should remember c3, b4, and a3 as long-term holes.



30. A quieter equalizing route

5.Nc3 a6 6.a3 d5 7.Nf3 Bg4 8.Be2 e6 9.0-0 Bd6

If White plays the more precise a3 setup, Black still gets a healthy game. It may be less dramatic, but the same pressure logic remains.

Chapter 6: How to Study This

Use the diagrams as positions to replay, not as decorations. Put each position on the board, name the target squares, and choose a move for both sides. Then return to the notes. If the move is not obvious, ask what changed since the previous diagram: a target, a pinned defender, a weak square, or a new attacking route.

Position family	Question to ask	Answer you want to remember
After ...Qb6	How does White defend b2 and d4?	Nc3 is principled; b3 weakens dark squares; greedy ...Qxb2 after Nc3 is dangerous.
After ...a6 and ...d5	What did ...a6 achieve?	It removed Nb5 before Black committed the center.
After ...Bg4	What is really pinned?	The defender of d4. The pin is a positional move.
After ...Qc7	Why leave b6?	The queen's job changed: c-file, e5, b5, and anti-b4 control matter more.
After ...b5	What is White's best lever?	a4. Black should respect it and avoid assuming the queenside is locked forever.
After ...Bxf3 and ...Nb8	What is Black playing for?	Piece occupation of c4, not merely filling the square with a pawn.
After ...Nh5 and ...Qd8	Why is the attack justified?	White's structure is damaged, g3/f4 are restrained, and the queen has a route to h4.

Final memory hook: challenge, exchange, question, cover b5, pin d4, improve, expand, reroute, switch fronts, calculate. That is the whole system in ten verbs.